

MGT 414: Rady Action Project

Spring 2026- Full Time MBA

Tuesdays 11:00am-1:50pm

Please review syllabus for additional meeting times and course schedule

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Office hours are available by appointment.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course provides you with external consulting experience which utilizes and builds upon the knowledge and skills acquired through work experience and in this course. The course enriches the Rady experiential learning component and provides an interdisciplinary approach to project execution and presentation. Projects are sponsored and guided by clients from the business community.

OBJECTIVES

- Gain a practical understanding of management consulting via hands-on experience working with a corporate client.
- Gain an in-depth understanding of advanced management techniques, including project and client management, communication, and team dynamics.
- Perfect use of business communications skills, oral and written, throughout the quarter, culminating in a final oral presentation and written executive summary.
- Learn best practices for aligning client expectations with realistic project goals and objectives through effective communication and consensus building.
- Create and deliver a well thought out and professionally executed final deliverable to the client.

MATERIALS

The readings listed below are necessary to complete the course successfully. They give students another perspective on consulting. All articles can be found on the course Canvas site under "Study. Net Materials."

Required Readings

The following readings and video should be completed before the 1st class meeting on 3/31.

1. *Principles of Effective Consulting*
2. *Consulting Is More Than Giving Advice*—Arthur N. Turner
3. *Pioneers, Drivers, Integrators, and Guardians*—Suzanne M. Johnson Vickberg & Kim Christfort (*Harvard Business Review*, 2017)
4. *Glossary of Consulting Terms*
5. **Video:** [*Is Consulting the Right Career for You?*](#)—Harvard Business Review

These readings are assigned throughout the quarter:

6. *Project Scoping* — University of Virginia, Darden Business Publishing (UV8820 Rev. May 29, 2024)
7. *Want Bulletproof Strategies? Become a Better Problem Solver*
8. *Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis* — Ivey Publishing (W1331)
9. *3 Steps to Identify the Right Strategic Goals for Your Company*

Supplemental Reading – These books are for those students interested in pursuing consulting.

- [Consulting 101: 101 Tips For Success in Consulting, by Lew Sauder](#)
- [Project Management Book of Knowledge \(PMBOK\)](#) by Project Management Institute (PMI) - FREE if you apply for student membership with PMI

PROJECTS

A Rady Action Project is sponsored by a company or organization. A typical project includes the following activities and can encompass a business problem that an MBA can solve.

- 1) Engaging clients to clarify the problem – interviewing, questioning.
 - b. Context
 - c. Background
 - d. Symptom
- 2) Structure the problem – fishbone diagram, etc.
 - a) Determine Cause
 - b) Revise if needed
- 3) Analyze research –think of all the possibilities
 - a) Develop solutions – how does it relate to root cause
- 4) Select a solution
 - a) Feasibility
 - b) Best Fit
- 5) Ongoing communication with the client throughout, sharing your insights and solutions, and revising as needed

Teams will consist of 3-6 students who receive project guidance from a project leader provided by the company and mentoring from your faculty. In addition, teams receive business communications coaching from industry and academic professionals. Students must bring their business skills and professionalism to the team to achieve project objectives. You are representing the Rady brand with our sponsors who are also employers, interested in hiring UCSD students.

COURSE WORKLOAD EXPECTATIONS

This course is structured for over **10** weeks. The course workload is estimated as follows:

Course Item	Estimated Hours
Research	2-3 hours/week
Problem Solving	2-3 hours/ week
Weekly Status Reports (Client and Internal) and Client Meeting Agenda	1-2 hours/ week
Work Plan Updates	1-2 hours/week
Individual Assignments	1-2 hours /week
Team Presentation Slides	2 hours/week
Final Presentation Practice	1 hour/week
Final Written Deliverables	1-2 hours/week

This averages approximately **11-12** hours/week. These estimates will vary depending on your existing knowledge level and/or time commitment.

MEETING SCHEDULE & STRUCTURE

I will lecture for 35-45 minutes each week and then meet with the individual teams afterwards. If students are not meeting with me, they should meet as a team or with their client(s).

Meetings	Time Frame	Documents	Participants
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Project Kickoff	Week 1: Friday 4/3, 8:30-11:30am General Session with Faculty followed by a 2-hour meeting between student team and client	Teams will develop project charter and schedule weekly client status meetings. Teams will submit their project charter on Canvas for faculty review before sending the final charter to the client.	Faculty, Team & Client
Client Status Meetings	Weekly: Week 2-7 Schedule determined by client and student team (may be scheduled outside of class time)	Email to Client 24 hours before meeting: 1) Client Status Report	Team & Client
Faculty/Team Meeting	Tuesdays: Week 2-6 during class time. Teams will be assigned a 15-minute time slot at the first class meeting on Tues 3/31.	Project teams will meet with faculty once a week for 15 minutes to discuss their client consulting projects, review project status, progress, client management, challenges, issues to address, and potential adjustments if necessary. Submit on Canvas 24 hours before Faculty meeting: 1) Work Plan 2) Client Status	Faculty & Team
Student Team Meetings	Tuesdays during class time: Week 1-9 & as needed	Tuesdays when you are not meeting with faculty, be prepared to discuss research and work for the week.	Student Team
Presentation For Communications Faculty	Week 5: Tuesday 4/28 Teams meet with the Communications faculty for 40 minutes: Time slots will be decided at the first class meeting on 3/31. Your session may be scheduled outside of our scheduled class time based on Cate's availability.	20-30-minute presentation and 10 minutes of feedback. Teams should select one member to take notes and send to both faculty.	Team & Comm Faculty
Internal presentation For Faculty	Tuesday Week 7 & 8: 5/12 & 5/19 Four presentations each week. Teams will be assigned a 40-minute time slot. Your attendance is only required during your time with the faculty.	20-30-minute presentations with 10-20 minutes of feedback. The week you are off you may use the time to work on your presentation.	Faculty & Teams
Client Final Presentation	Tuesday Week 9 & 10: 5/25 & 6/2 Four presentations each week. Teams will be assigned a 40-minute time slot during class time. Students are required to attend both presentation days.	Present to client for 20-30 minutes and 10 minutes for client feedback. ½ class will present week 9 and the other in week 10.	Faculty, Teams & Client

COURSE SCHEDULE

Week 0: Prior to Start of Class

- Complete Project Selection Survey by 2/20 @ 12:00 PM
- Readings & Video completed before first class on 3/31:
 - *Principles of Effective Consulting*
 - *Consulting Is More Than Giving Advice*—Arthur N. Turner
 - *Pioneers, Drivers, Integrators, and Guardians*—Suzanne M. Johnson Vickberg & Kim Christfort (*Harvard Business Review*, 2017)
 - *Glossary of Consulting Terms*
 - **Video:** [*Is Consulting the Right Career for You?*](#)—Harvard Business Review

Week/Module	Meeting Dates	Class Topic & Activities	Assignments Due
Week 1 March 30- April 5	Class Tuesday, March 31: 11am-1:50pm	Lecture: Introductions, Consulting, Confidentiality, Teaming, Kick-Off, Problem Solving Group/Class Discussion: How will you approach time management and planning? Weekly Faculty Team Meetings and Communication Consultations will be scheduled.	Submit on Canvas by 4/1@ 11:59 pm: Team Contract (15pts) Review the Project Charter for kick-off Readings: • <i>Project Scoping</i> • <i>Want better Strategies? Be A Better Problem Solver</i>
	Client Kickoff Friday, April 3: 8:30-11:30am General Session followed by Client break	Objectives: 1) Develop Project Charter 2) Schedule time for weekly client meetings 3) Give Client dates of final presentations: - Week 9: May 19th - Week 10: May 26th	Submit on Canvas 4/5@ 11:59pm: Project Charter (50pts)
Week 2 April 6-12	Class <u>April 7: 11am-1:50pm</u> • 11-11:45am: Lecture	Lecture: Client Status Reports, Work Plan, and Research Group/Class Discussion: How will you manage Client expectations?	
	• 11:45am-1:50 pm: Team Meetings with Faculty/ project work time	Faculty Meeting	Submit on Canvas by 4/12 @11:59pm: • Client Status Report (4pts) • Work Plan (2pts)
		Client Meeting	Send to Client 24 hours in advance: Client Status report Project Charter due to client by 4/12 following faculty revisions and approval

Week 3 April 13-19	Class <u>April 14: 11am-1:50pm</u> 11-11:45am: Lecture 11:45am-1:50 pm: Team Meetings with Faculty/ project work time	Lecture: Strategic Selling, Client Management, and Setting Expectations Group/Class Discussion: People Management- Relationship map	Submit on Canvas by 4/19 @11:59pm: Case Analysis Reading: <i>Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis</i> Review the case and submit your responses to Questions 1-3 on Canvas (2 pages-30 pts) 1. What is the role of Jones in the case . How she perceives her role and also how Alvarez sees her role(Hint – Review Week 1 slides)? 4 points -2 pts each 2. What are three big issues facing the SFT team of directors? 12 pts -4pts each 3. What are your 3 recommendations? 12pts – 4pts each 4. No written response required— Take a moment to imagine you're creating a client relationship map. Think about how each personality connects with others and with Alvarez.
		Faculty Meeting	Submit on Canvas by 4/19 @11:59pm • Client Status Report (4pts) • Work Plan (2pts)
		Client Meeting	Send to Client 24 hours in advance: Client Status report
Week 4 April 20-26	Class <u>April 21: 11am-1:50pm</u> 11-11:45am: Lecture 11:45-1:50 pm Team Meetings with Faculty/ project work time	Lecture: Overview of Top Frameworks & Presentation Format • Group Discussion: How has the work plan helped /or not helped with planning and time management?	Reading: <i>3 Steps to Identify the Right Strategic Goals for your Company</i> Submit on Canvas by 4/26 @11:59pm: Midterm Peer Review
		Faculty Meeting	Submit on Canvas by 4/26 @11:59pm • Client Status Report (4pts) • Work Plan (2pts)
		Client Meeting	Send to Client 24 hours in advance:

			Client Status report
Week 5 April 27-May 3	Class <u>April 28: 11:45am-1:50pm</u> Your team's consultation may be scheduled outside of class hours based on Cate's availability.	Present to the Communications Faculty – each team will have 45 minutes. 20 -30-minute presentation, 15 min feedback	Submit on Canvas 5/3@11:59 pm • Client Status Report (4pts) • Work Plan (2pts)
		Client Meeting	Send to Client 24 hours in advance: Client Status report
Week 6 May 4-10	May 5th <u>NO Lecture</u> Meet with Sandy during Team Meeting	Meet as a team and revise your presentation after your session with Cate.	Submit on Canvas by 5/10 @11:59pm • Client Status Report (4pts) • Work Plan (2pts)
		Client Meeting	Send to Client 24 hours in advance: Client Status report
Week 7 May 11-17	<u>May 12: 11am-1:50pm</u> No Lecture or Team Meetings Your team will only attend during your scheduled time.	Internal Presentation (Part 1) Each team will have 20-30 presentation and 10 minutes of feedback	Submit on Canvas by 5/17 @11:59pm • Client Status Report (4pts) • Work Plan (2pts)
		Final Client Meeting	Send to Client 24 hours in advance: Client Status report
Week 8 May 18-24	<u>May 19th 11am-1:50pm</u> Teams will only attend during scheduled time.	Internal Presentation (Part 2) Each team will have 20-30 presentation 10-minute feedback	Submit on Canvas; by 5/19 @11:59pm: • Presentation Slides (50 pts) Submit on Canvas by 5/24 @11:59pm • Final Work Plan (2pts) • Client Status Report (4pts)
Week 9 May 25-31	Class May 25: 11am-1:50 pm	Final Presentations to Clients (Part 1) 20-30-minute presentation & 10minutes Client discussion Your team will be assigned a presentation time that has been coordinated with your client and scheduled during class time. Half of the class will present in Week 9, and the remaining teams will present in Week 10. All students are required to attend every	Submit on Canvas 5/31 @11:59pm • Executive Summary (50pts) • Work Cited (10pts) • Final Peer Review Survey due 5/31@11:59pm (150 pts) Submit on Canvas: • Final Client presentation slides due 5/31 @11:59pm (75pts) Final Peer Review Survey due 5/31@11:59pm (150 pts)

		presentation. You will also be required to sign an NDA.	
Week 10 June 1-7	Class June 2: 11am-1:50pm	Final Presentations to Clients (Part 2) 20-30-minute presentation & 10 minutes Client discussion	Submit on Canvas: • Final Client presentation slides due 6/3 @11:59pm (75pts) Submit all final deliverables to Canvas and to client 6/7 -Send all materials to clients following faculty revisions and approval: • Executive Summary • Work Cited • Presentation Slides • Additional Deliverables
Finals Week June 8-12	No Class: Submit all final deliverables to the Client(s) after faculty review.		

ASSIGNMENTS

I – Independent, individual work only. No collaboration or consultation allowed.

G – Students will work together in groups and turn in one project or assignment for the entire group.

Course Grading	Course Work	Points
G	Team Contract	15
G	Client Status Reports (Week 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7,) 4 pts each	24
G	Project Charter	50
G	Work Plan (Week 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7,): 2pts each	12
I	Case Analysis Assignment: <i>Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis</i>	28
I	Class Attendance: 2 pts each – Including week 9&10 Week 1 two sessions. Either week 7 or 8 based on scheduling	20
G	Class Discussion Participation (Week 1, 2, 3, 4,)4 pts each	16
G	Ex. Summary	50
G	Work Cited	10
G & I	Final Internal Presentation	50
G & I	Final Client Presentation	75
I	Professionalism/Participation Grade	150
	Total	500

Written Assignments & Discussions

1. **Class Attendance (I):** You will receive 2 pts each week for attendance.
2. **Class Discussions (G):** You will also receive 4 pts for participating in each of our in-class discussion and one online discussion (Week 1, 3, 4, 6).
3. **Team Contract (G):** Outlines the roles and procedures the team will follow throughout the project.
4. **Project Charter (G)** – Outlines the current client situation (business opportunity or challenge), project goals, scope of work, milestones and associated timelines, deliverables, risk assessment, and the basic terms and conditions under which the work will be performed.
5. **Work Plan(G)** – The detailed weekly breakdown of the scope of work milestones. WP is for internal use only and **not shared with the client**. You may input your project into ChatGPT and ask it to break down your tasks and milestones for your work plan. Although I will need names and details on the project plan.
6. **Client Status Reports (G)** – The client status report is due to the client 24 hours in advance. This document allows the client to stay up to date on the progress of the project. You will also submit the client status report weekly into canvas.
7. **Case Assignment (I)-** Review the case *Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis* and answer the questions; submit two-pages to Canvas.
8. **Executive Summary (G)** - Approximately 1–2-page summary of project purpose, methodology, analysis, findings, actionable recommendations, and next steps, as applicable. The key is to be concise.
9. **Works Cited (G)** – Reference listings, providing all sources utilized during the quarter. This document will be graded based on the criteria for proper APA citation.
10. **Final Presentations (G & I):**
Internal Final Presentation to Faculty –Final opportunity to refine presentation before giving final client presentation. Each team has a scheduled time

Final Client Presentation – Final presentation to the client. This is the culmination of the project work. Your final internal and client presentation will be graded on your ability to communicate your results clearly and effectively translate them to your audience, your pace and transitions, and the relevance and quality of your analysis and explanation of research, as well as its connection to business goals.

11. PROFESSIONALISM

Professionalism is defined as participating actively in every aspect of your project and operating as an effective team member and student. The professionalism grade is drawn from peer and faculty grading.

PEER GRADING (I)

At weeks 5 and 10 of the quarter, each student will complete and submit a “peer evaluation” form on Canvas. Students will be asked to provide feedback on the contributions of their teammates. Submitting this form is considered part of your class participation grade.

FACULTY GRADING

Faculty will provide feedback about each team member’s contribution to the project.

The criteria are:

- Showing up for meetings on time and being prepared for discussion
- Demonstrating understanding of the project and your contribution to the research and outcome
- Demonstrating active leadership
- Communication and Professional Dress while engaging with the client
- Effective Listening and incorporating feedback given during your project development

GRADING

Percentage	Letter Grade	Points
90-100	A	450 -500
80-89	B	400-449
70-79	C	350-399

COURSE POLICIES

ATTENDANCE

This is an in-person class; the faculty must be notified 24 hours in advance if a student is planning not to attend.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.